took the message of the faith across the country. Despite Shankara's skill in debate, Advaita nonetheless believes that pure logic cannot alone lead to philosophical truths; knowledge is all very well, but experience and meditative insights are essential too. Shankara's Advaita Vedanta was based on *shastra* ('scriptures'), *pramanas* or *yukti* ('reason') and *anubhava* ('experiential knowledge'), supplemented by *karmas* ('spiritual practices') and the purity and steadiness of mind achieved in yoga. None was sufficient in itself: the entire package, as it were, allowed the seeker to gain the knowledge and insights required to attain self-realisation.

Shankara also proposed the four '*mahavakyas*' or 'great sentences' of his doctrine—'Prajnanam Brahma' (knowledge is Brahman), 'Ayam Atma Brahma' (this atman is Brahman), 'Tat tvam asi' (that you are), and 'Aham Brahmasmi' (I am Brahman)—as the guiding principles of Hindu spiritual contemplation, all of which underscored his doctrine that the inner immortal soul, atman, and the great cosmic spirit, Brahman, are really one and the same. Atman and Brahman had been regarded by the 'dualist' Sankhya School of thought as separate entities, but Shankara argued that while they might seem different at the empirical level of reality, this is an illusion. Brahman, the spirit that suffuses the cosmos, is the sole reality; other than Brahman, everything else, including the universe, material objects and individuals, is ever changing, transient and illusory (*maya*). (As Radhakrishnan was later to explain, *maya* is not merely illusion, but 'a subjective misperception of the world as ultimately real.') Brahman is Paramarthika Satyam, Absolute Truth, and one's *atman* or self is identical to it. Realising this and accepting the true self, pure consciousness, as the only reality (*sat*), leads to *moksha* or salvation, defined by some as a state of bliss (*ananda*) and by others, more modestly, as the endless but not beginningless absence of pain, the pain all human beings suffer in the course of their ordinary lives. The supreme truth of Brahman is *sat-chit-ananda* (truth-consciousness-bliss), as Shankara wrote in his *Upadeshasahasri*:

I am other than name, form and action.
My nature is ever free!
I am Self, the supreme unconditioned Brahman.
I am pure Awareness, always non-dual.